

Introducing the “mini-paper” writing exercise

What is it?

Purpose

What should I write about?

Use of AI

How much time will we have in class to work on it?

Introducing the “mini-paper”

You will write a “mini-paper” over the next few weeks. Despite the name, this is not a full paper: it is a piece of writing in the style of an introduction (so you are **not** going to write the abstract, method, results, or discussion).

About 400-500 words.

Style of writing: academic.

Submit in week 6 – 20% of grade.

This is pretty much the only compulsory homework of the course – so you will be busy until week 6 but not after week 6.

Needs to be written 100% by you (so, for example, you cannot use an introduction you wrote with your supervisor and three of your lab colleagues).

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Purposes

1. Practice producing the structure of an introduction that we've been discussing. If you don't really understand OCAR and the hourglass yet, you will once you've finished this task.

(To be clear, you are going to write an introduction only, so you will be practising only the O and C parts of OCAR and the hourglass.)

2. Create a convenient sample of your academic writing. When we learn some ideas about writing style etc in weeks 8-14, you will practise these ideas by editing and improving your mini-paper.

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You can write a real introduction

If you're currently working on a research project, you can write an introduction to your current work.

Though remember, I was a chemist... a long time ago... and now I am an English teacher.

If your research area is highly technical, I will struggle to understand it.

Especially, if your research area is even moderately mathematical, it's unlikely I will be able to understand it. If I cannot understand it, I will not be able to give you (i) a grade or (ii) feedback.

Based on past experience, I am likely to find it ok to read:

- biomedicine, medicine, earth science, robotics, some areas of computer science, some areas of finance and management

You can also write a totally fictional introduction

You can pretend you've just invented something (fire, rain, roofs, birds, cups, whatever) and you're writing the introduction of a paper about it.

This may sound a little silly or childish, but it works well:

- Doesn't require you to be doing any research at present
- No need to think about the science – can concentrate on the writing
- Allows you to practise all of the relevant scientific writing ideas
- Easy for me (and other students) to understand and read, so you'll get more feedback on your writing style and grammar

I'll share some examples later.

Real or fictional introduction?

If you have a real research project to which you **want** to write an introduction

AND

The project is about something I can understand so that I will be able to mark your introduction and give you useful feedback (ask me about it if you're not sure)

THEN

Write a real introduction

OTHERWISE

Write a fictional introduction

Advice: don't dismiss the idea of writing a fictional introduction just because it sounds silly. It often works well as a writing exercise.

Overall, about 60% of students each year write something fictional, and about 40% write something real.

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AI

We will have a lesson on AI in week 4 in which I will justify the approach/rules below. For now, I will just state them briefly:

- You cannot use AI to write your mini-paper for you
- You cannot write the whole paper in Chinese then use machine translation to turn it into English

This is partly because your mini-paper needs to be useful for editing practice in weeks 8-14. In those weeks, we will be looking at many principles for clear writing and you will practise applying them by editing your mini-paper. If your mini-paper has been written with too much AI help, it will not be useful for editing practice.

Equally, I don't want you to struggle too much, so you can use AI/translation a bit to help you with particularly difficult parts:

- You can use AI/machine translation to help you with up to 50% of the sentences. You will need to highlight these sentences.
- There will be a grade penalty if I do not believe that you wrote at least 50% of sentences unaided.
- "AI" includes Grammarly and similar tools.

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How much time will we have in class to work on it?

How much time will we have in class to work on it before submission?

Today: about ____ minutes

Week 3: 0-30 minutes depending on the speed of the lesson

Week 4: 0-30 minutes depending on the speed of the lesson

Week 5: 0-30 minutes depending on the speed of the lesson, and we will try to find 20 minutes to do some peer review

Week 6: submit

Starting your mini-paper

Start writing your introduction (i.e. an **opening** and a **challenge**).

Remember, the **opening** helps us:

- Understand what the big ideas are and why they matter
- Understand the **challenge** and why it is valid, sensible, interesting

The **challenge** tells us clearly what question/problem the paper will answer/solve

If you're going to write a fictional introduction:

- Pick something (almost anything) and pretend you've invented it.
- Have a look at the example document

